Revision Date:
06/01/2026

Background:
Students enrolled in an institution of higher education must meet student eligibility criteria for CalFresh.

Purpose:
This section defines student eligibility for CalFresh and provides guidance on exemptions. This section is being revised to include the following:

- Updated assessment process for Local Programs that Increase Employability (LPIE).
- Clarification on Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) Funded Cal Grant A and B, summer enrollment, and Adult Education Programs.

Policy:
1. Institution of Higher Education

A student is considered enrolled in an institution of higher education if they are in a:

- Business, technical, trade, or vocational school that normally requires a high school diploma or equivalent certificate.
- Regular curriculum at a college or university that offers degree programs regardless of a high school diploma.

Enrollment status is determined by the school and may be verified using student statement or information gathered while completing the Student Eligibility Worksheet (09-55 HHSA). Enrollment begins on the first day of the school term and will continue through normal class attendance and vacation, unless the student graduates, is suspended, drops out, or does not intend to register for the next school term.

2. Evaluating Student Status

Evaluate student status at intake and recertification (RE). Student status is not a mandatory mid-period reporting requirement and is not considered Verified Upon Receipt (VUR). If student status is reported mid-period, document the voluntarily reported change in the case record, the reason for not acting on the change, and send a No-Change Notice of Action (NOA). The NOA must remind the household (HH) to report the information at the next Eligibility Status Report (SAR 7) or RE, whichever comes first. Act only on changes that will increase the CalFresh allotment except for mandatory mid-period reports and information that is considered VUR.

3. Summer Enrollment

Students who submit an initial application for benefits in the summer before their first official day of the regular school term are not considered students for CalFresh at the time of application. Reassess their student status at RE. Continuing students are subject to student eligibility rules during regular school breaks.

4. Adult Education Programs

The following adult education programs are considered non-regular curriculums and are not considered institutions of higher education for CalFresh:

- Adult education programs.

- Remedial education.
- Continuing or community education.
- Professional development.
- English for speakers of other languages.
- Workforce development and training programs.
- Enrollment in kindergarten through grade 12 (K-12) adult schools.
- Community college non-credit classes that do not require a high school diploma or equivalency certificate.

5. Eligibility Requirements

Only one exemption is needed to qualify a student for CalFresh, however it is mandatory to document all exemptions being claimed in the case record. If a student loses an exemption, assess whether the student meets the criteria for another exemption before taking negative action. Complete the 09-55 HHSA when determining student eligibility and image the form into the case record.

Students must meet one of the following exemptions to be eligible for CalFresh:

- Age 17 or younger.
- Age 50 or older.
- Physically or mentally unfit for employment.
  - This may be a temporary or permanent illness, disability, or life circumstance that reduces the student's ability to work an average of 20 hours a week on an ongoing basis.
  - If a student's unfitness is not apparent, the exemption may be verified by receipt of temporary or permanent disability benefits or with a statement from a doctor or licensed psychologist. A student's statement or affidavit is not sufficient verification.
  - Indicators of apparent unfitness include but are not limited to chronic homelessness, struggling with substance use, and having experienced domestic violence.
- Enrolled less than half time.
  - The definition of enrolled half time is being registered each term to half the number of credits required to graduate within four years as a first time freshman or two years as a transfer student.
- Disabled and receiving disability-based income:
  - For example, Social Security Disability, Supplemental Security Income, Veterans Disability, Worker's Compensation, or other disability-based income qualify for an exemption.
  - The disability must be expected to last more than 30 days.
- Receiving TANF Funded Cal Grant, A or B. To qualify for TANF funded cash or non-cash benefits the student must be:
  - Unmarried;
  - 25 years of age or younger; and
  - Have parental and/or student income of $50,000 a year or less.

Note: Cal Grant A is typically awarded to students at four-year institutions of higher education due to the California Promise grant that is awarded to undergraduate students at California Community Colleges (CCCs) that covers tuition and fees.

- Does not expect to be enrolled next term.
  - Due to the student graduating, suspension/expulsion, dropping out, or not intending to register for the next normal school term (excluding summer school).

Example 1	
Scenario	The student applies in February but states they plan to graduate in June
Outcome	The student is not subject to the student eligibility criteria.
Example 2	
Scenario	The student applies in March but states they do not plan to return to school in the fall.
Outcome	The student is not subject to the student eligibility criteria.

- Receive California Work Opportunity and Responsibility to Kids (CalWORKs), Tribal TANF, or another program funded with the TANF block grant under Title IV of the Social Security Act such as the Job Opportunities and Basic Skills (JOBS) program.
- Enrolled in Workforce Innovation Opportunity Act (WIOA).
  - San Diego Workforce Partnership (SDWP) administers the WIOA programs and determines who qualifies for WIOA funded training at local educational institutions.
  - Additional information on WIOA can be found here: https://workforce.org/training-wioa/.
- Approved for Work Study.
  - Must be approved, awarded, or accepted for state or federally financed Work Study for the current school term and anticipated working during the term.
  - Exemption would begin the month the school term begins, or the month Work Study is approved, whichever is later. The exemption will end the month the school term ends or if the student refuses a Work Study position.
  - For treatment of Work Study income refer to Section 63-222 Earned Income.
- Participating in CalFresh Employment and Training (CFET).
- Participating in a LPIE.
  - Effective June 1, 2026, all associate and bachelor's degree programs offered by the following campuses are approved statewide as General Programs under LPIE.
    - CCC.
    - University of California (UC).
    - California State University (CSU).
  - A student that has not declared a major but is enrolled in general education courses required to obtain an associate or bachelor's degree is eligible for this exemption.

Note: Students in graduate/advanced degree programs, certificate programs, career and technical education programs, apprenticeship programs must continue to be reviewed for specific campus based programs on the CalFresh Student Eligibility: List of Approved LPIEs list found at www.cdss.ca.gov/inforesources/calfresh-resource-center/policy. This list is updated monthly on the California Department of Social Services (CDSS) website. Programs at private institutions continue to be excluded and cannot be LPIEs.

- Participating in an on-the-job training program.
- Work at least 20 hours per week or a total of 80 hours per month in paid employment.
  - When calculating hours worked, average the hours using the multiplier 4.33 or the number of weeks in the year.
  - For self-employed students, determine the average hours by dividing the net income by federal minimum wage.

Note: Net income is the gross income minus the standard or actual deduction (whichever the student chose).

Example 1: Using 4.33 Multiplier	
Scenario	A student provides their pay stubs showing they work 19 hours per week. Even though the student does not work 20 hours per week, they do work more than an average of 80 hours or more each month.
Outcome	Average hours: 19 hours per week x 4.33 = 82.77 hours per month. The student is eligible for the paid work exemption.
Example 2: Using Number of Weeks in the Year	
Scenario	A student provides their previous month's pay stubs showing they work 16 hours per week. This student does not work an average of 20 hours per week and does not maintain an average of at least 80 hours per month.
Outcome	Average hours: 16 hours per week x 52 weeks per year = 832 hours per year/12 months = 69.33 hours per month. The student is not eligible for the paid work exemption.

  - If the student reports a change in work hours on the SAR 7, determine whether the work hours average to 20 hours per week or an average of 80 hours per month to continue with this exemption.
  - If the change in work hours does not average 20 hours per week or an average of 80 hours per month, determine if the student meets another exemption.
- A single parent enrolled full time in college and exerting parental care and control of a child under age 12.
- Exerting parental care and control for a child:
  - Under the age of 6.
  - Aged 6-11 and the student does not have adequate childcare to attend school and work 20 hours per week or participate in Work Study.

Note: If two students exert parental care and control in the HH, allow the exemption status for only one. If there is more than one child under age 12 and it is reported that each student exerts care and control for a separate child, explore the exemption. Evaluate why one student is unable to care for all or the reason why each student is "responsible" for separate children.

6. Ineligible Students

Students who do not meet any of the exemptions listed above are ineligible and will be considered excluded HH members. Ineligible students' income and resources are exempt from benefit determination. Refer to Section 63-255 Treatment of Income and Expenses of Ineligible and Non-Household Members for guidance on treatment of ineligible students' income and resources.

7. Student Meal Plans

Students who live on campus and receive more than half their meals from a meal plan are considered residents of an institution and are ineligible for CalFresh benefits. There are 21 meals in a week (3 meals a day over 7 days per week). Students who live on campus and whose meal plan provides half of their meals (ten meals per week) may qualify for CalFresh benefits if all other eligibility criteria are met.

Review mandatory and optional meal plans and the college website to obtain the latest meal plan information to determine eligibility for CalFresh. Students who live off campus are not considered residents of an institution and are potentially eligible for CalFresh, even if they have a meal plan that provides more than half their daily meals. CalFresh benefits cannot be used to pay for college meal plans.

8. Verification of Student Exemptions

A student's statement is sufficient to verify a student exemption. Verification of student exemption should only be requested when the information provided by the student is questionable or a student's claim of physical or mental unfitness is not apparent. Refer to Section 63-117 Verification and Documentation for more information on questionable information. The case record must document all student exemptions.

Non-receipt of financial aid may be verified by student statement and must be documented in the case record. Federal or state government-funded grants, awards, scholarships, loans, or fellowships conferred for the purposes of attending higher educational institutions are exempt income. Evaluate the source of education-related income to determine whether to exempt it or count it when determining eligibility and benefit amounts. Educational related income and calculations must be documented in the case record.

For students receiving TANF-funded Cal Grant A or B, if the student's attestation is questionable, the California Student Aid Commission (CSAC) provides students with an electronic or paper letter regarding their potential eligibility for CalFresh. This letter serves as verification that a student receives this exemption as only TANF-funded Cal Grant A or B recipients receive this letter.

Eligibility staff must continue to verify the HH' s gross nonexempt income, including any educational assistance and/or stipends including but not limited to Department of Veteran Affairs (VA) housing and subsistence payment portions of VA educational benefits. These educational benefits are counted as income. Refer to Section 63-222 Earned Income and 63-224 Income Exclusions, for guidance on treatment of Students income.

Procedure:
09-55 HHSA.

Program Impacts:
None.

References:
All County Letters (ACLs) 26-25, 24-31, 22-46, 21-101, 21-58, 20-34, 19-93, 19-32, 18-27, 17-97, 17-05, 17-05E.
All County Information Notices (ACINs) I-89-15.
Manual Policies and Procedures (MPP) 63-406.1; 63-300.5; 7.
Code of Federal Regulations (CFR) 273.5, 273.2(f)(1)(i), 273.2(f)(2).

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance on or by 05/31/2029.

Approval for Release:



Alberto Banuelos, Ph.D., Interim Director
Self-Sufficiency Services